

Game for FAME

Answering people's call for easy success, television channels are frenetically churning out reality shows that are more extreme than their predecessors

By Jhilmil Motihar |

When Anil Shinde appeared on Zee TV's *Shabaash India*, no one knew what he was going to do. He lit 400 candles, waited till they melted and poured the wax all over his bare torso. On his second shot at television on Sony's *Entertainment Ke Liye Kuch Bhi Karega*, he upped the gamble to 500 candles. "I would have lit camphor sticks and stuck them to my body if I had been chosen for the finals," says the daredevil from Mumbai.

Mumbai boy Sufi Malhotra, a vegetarian, glugged raw eggs to prove he was, indeed, a *Roadie*. Chandigarh's Suyash Rai didn't stop till he found his two minutes in front of the camera. He auditioned for *Roadies* twice and finally landed himself in the Goa house of *Splitsvilla* 2. "I couldn't be happier. It's my first step to becoming famous," says Rai, who's given up studies and moved to Mumbai. For these tiny specks among the hordes waiting to be almost famous, television is the answer. It's the place where abusing a co-contestant gets you 200 fans on Orkut while letting a spider crawl over your face gets you closer to Rs 50 lakh. And more often than not, it's all done without a dime. Contestants on



ENTERTAINMENT KE LIYE KUCH BHI KAREGA SONY

Women sing like men, men dance like women. It's called fame, a growing addiction.

Roadies and *Splitsvilla* vie not for the Rs 5 lakh cash prize. In fact, they have to dole out money for a wardrobe specified by MTV. They dream of becoming a *vj* like Bani, a *tv* actor like Mohit Malhotra or simply famous for being famous like Ashutosh Kaushik. This is what Sunil Lulla, CEO of Real, calls the young and famous quotient. "People are increasingly willing to do anything that gets them peer approval," says Lulla.

Is it surprising then that

every TV channel worth its TRP is brainstorming to come up with a reality show that's more extreme than its predecessor. If *Bigg Boss* on Sony and then Colors confined participants to a house, *Sarkar Ki Duniya* on Real has barricaded them on an island near Karnataka. All that the motley crew of unknown people has is each other and some livestock. Banking on the same formula, Sony TV has planned the Indian version of *I'm a Celebrity, Get Me Out of Here*. Quite literally translating it into *Is Jungle Se Mujhe Bachao*, the show will be shot in Malaysia and might see C-listers like Jiah Khan, Sameera Reddy and Upen Patel claw and coo in the wild.

Spurred by the success of *Fear Factor* on Colors that averaged a TRP of 4.2, Endemol, the production house, will soon start work on Indianising two other international reality formats. *Wipe Out*, an obstacle course, will be shot in Argentina, while *Estate of Panic* will throw participants in a house caving in. "In India it's important for a show to have



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